Vietnam, Tale

Folktale, Vietnamese

Van Pham, Female, 53
Manicurist, Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam/ 1st Gen. Asian American
Vietnamese
Home, San Diego, California
September 14, 2007

TEXT

Tam and Cam

A family live together a long time ago. The husband, wife, and daughter name Tam all very happy. One day the wife die and the husband marry again. The second wife is a very bad person. They have a second daughter name Cam. The new wife love Cam very much , but hate Tam.

She make Tam do all the work in the house and sleep in the kitchen. Tam wear dirty clothes and work a lot but still very beautiful. The stepmom very jealous of how pretty Tam look. She tell Tam and Cam to go fish in the pond. She tell them to catch a lot of fish or she will beat them.

Tam catch a basketful of fish and Cam do nothing all day. Cam tell Tam to get clean in the pond so stepmom don't get mad. When Tam wash in the water, Cam take all Tam's fish and run home. When Tam done she see that all her fish stolen, she start to cry. The Goddess appear to help her. Tam tell her everything. The Goddess tell Tam to look in the basket.

Tam see one fish left. The Goddess tell her to take the fish home, put in well behind the house and feed three times a day. Tam say thank you to the Goddess and then go home. She feed the fish three times like the Goddess say. The stepmom notice this and catch the fish and eat it when Tam not home. When Tam come home, she go to the well and called, but the fish never come up. She see blood on the water and know what happen. Tam start to cry again. The Goddess appear and tell her not to cry. The Goddess tell her to find the fish bones and bury it in the ground and pray. Tam do what Goddess say. She get jewelry and expensive dress.

Han Pham, 24
2219 Channing Way #1, Berkeley

Soon Autumn Festival come. The stepmom order Tam to stay home until she sort two big basket of black and green beans. Tam cried to heaven and pray for help. The Goddess appear right away. She magically sort the beans for Tam. Tam stop to cry and put on her dress. She go to the festival and see Cam and her stepmom. She get scared and run home. Her slipper fall off when she run.

The king see the slipper want to find the owner. He say that anyone who fit the slipper will be queen. Everyone at the party try on but the slipper too small. Then he make all girls everywhere try on. Tam fit the slipper so she marry the king and become queen. The stepmom and Cam very jealous.

On her dad's birthday, Tam come home to celebrate with the family. All kids supposed to listen to parents in Vietnamese tradition. The stepmom know this and ask Tam to climb a tall tree to pick fruit to eat. Tam very good daughter so she climb the tree. The stepmom cut it down when she up there and Tam fall and die. The king see that Tam die and he have to take Cam as queen.

Tam's soul is unhappy, so it become a tree. The tree have only one fruit. The fruit is very big and pretty. A old woman see the beautiful fruit and pick it to take home. The next day, the woman come home and find her house clean, and a hot meal on the table. Next morning the old woman pretend to go, but she hide and watch in the window. She see a lady come out of the fruit and start to clean. After the old woman know, the lady stay in the house and take the old woman for her mom.

One day, the king go hunting and get lost. He see the old woman's house and ask for place to stay. The woman offer him tea and food. The king see the way meal made. It look like the way his first wife make. The old woman say that her daughter make it. The king want the

daughter to come out. He see that she is Tam. They both happy and Tam go back to be his wife and queen again.

Cam is jealous to be second wife and ask Tam how to be more beautiful. Tam know that Cam is a bad person. She tell her to wash in very hot water to make her skin whiter. Cam believe her and jump into hot water. Cam die right away. When the stepmom find out, she cry until she die too. Tam now live happy with the king.

TEXTURE

This is a bedtime story my mother told me when I was a child. I asked her to retell it to me for a different purpose now that I am older. Although she told me this in the middle of the day, she used the same delivery she did for her bedtime stories. Her voice was soothing and casual. She kept her gestures to a minimum and her tone was consistently soft throughout the entire performance. Despite her grammatical errors, she still effectively narrates the general plot. In this instance, her delivery made more of an impact than the story itself.

CONTEXT

My mom learned of this story from her mother when she was a child in Saigon, Vietnam in the late 1950s or early 1960s. Her mother told her many stories when she was a kid. As a language teacher in Vietnam, my mom also passed these stories on to her younger students. This one was very popular story among the kids. It parallels the American version called Cinderella.

She remembers mainly adults transmitting folktales to younger children. Older kids no longer had an interest in fairytales and found no use for them in conversations with their friends.

ANALYSIS/ Annotation

This is one of the most told stories from Vietnamese tradition. It unsurprisingly conforms to the feminist notion that women are portrayed in a negative light. The virtuous female character has no agency. She does what her stepmother tells her to without objection. Her contribution to the household involves cleaning, cooking, and everything related to the woman's realm. In the absence of a father figure, her stepmother takes on the male role and confines her to the kitchen. Tam helplessly surrenders every time a problem arises. She resorts to relying on the Goddess for assistance.

The Goddess is a significant figure in Buddhist teachings. She protects communities that honor her, similar to Patron Saints in the Christian faith. She represents the only positive female figure in the entire narrative. Her presence, although encouraging and helpful to Tam, does not necessarily contribute to a positive portrayal of women as a whole. She represents a powerful entity that possesses abilities beyond that of an average woman. Her existence sets impossible standards for women to live up to.

The antagonist of this story is the wicked stepmother. She embodies another one of the female archetypes commonly seen in folk narratives, the bad or evil mother. Her malicious nature gives her agency to plot against Tam. The underlining message is that good women listen and obey. Bad women do as they please and face terrible fates.

My mom, the contributor of this story, believes that that narrative exhibits many long-established Vietnamese customs. Buddhist teachings appear several times in the narrative. Tam's rebirth as a tree closely adheres to the Buddhist concept of reincarnation. Her sister and stepmother demonstrate the consequences of karma when they met their premature demise. Fish play a large part throughout the narrative. This exemplifies how important previous generations considered them. They served as the main source of nourishment for many fishing villages.

Another thing to consider is the traditional ideals of beauty in Asian societies. Many women during that time believed that attractiveness equates small feet and white skin, because this particular definition of beauty correlates to a high social status. Women from wealthier backgrounds usually enjoyed a less demanding way of life. They did not have to overexert themselves like the working-class. Women from underprivileged families had to endure rough working conditions in the fields, resulting in their darkened pigmentation and larger hands and feet. Filial duties also played an important part in Vietnamese society. Confucius principles greatly affected how children interacted with their parents. Respect for elders and parents came before anything else.

The narrative of this story is quite similar to the one found in Thế Giới Publishers', *Vietnamese Legends and Folk-Tales*, (Hanoi, Thế Giới Publishers, 1997), pg. 151-161. Both plots follow the same chronological order, but the published text is more grammatically correct and detailed. My mom's version leaves out several parts of the narrative and does not include dialogue. The text incorporates dialogue to help tell the story. She used this folktale as a way to put me to sleep as a child. These tales were a way of acquainting me with my heritage and entertaining me at the same time. The printed text has a different purpose. It widely circulates among the general population and no longer gets personally passed on between family members.